

Chapter 147-2

Gu Yixue finished smoking by the window, waved her hand to disperse the smell, closed the window, pulled her coat tighter, and returned to her seat.

Liang Shi, however, was completely absorbed in reading the script.

The main storyline of Gu Yixue's film was simple—it was about two women finding mutual redemption in turbulent times. Talking about ideals during chaotic times was no different from a pipe dream, yet they dared to talk about them.

The film focused heavily on a woman named Huang Shan. She was a woman who had been influenced by new progressive ideas—she attended school, participated in movements, ran about calling for civil rights, had been thrown in prison, had been subjected to mob justice, yet still continued to explore this path.

It could be said that she had devoted everything to this era of chaos.

Not a single day passed without her yearning for the chaos to end and for peace under heaven.

The other female lead, Guan Qingmin, grew up in a private school¹. She was well-versed in the Four Books and Five Classics², and the most unconventional book she had ever read was "Dream of the Red Chamber"³. Her daily life consisted of reading and embroidery, confined to her chambers for over a decade.

Guan Qingmin's parents had arranged her marriage early on—to the son of her father's colleague. This man was greedy and lecherous, frequenting brothels regularly. But because his father could assist her father in his official career, Guan Qingmin's father had her become engaged to him.

Guan Qingmin's father was a typical traitor in these turbulent times. He held immense power in Guangping City, but it was power gained through collaborating with the enemy and betraying his country.

The students in Guangping City hated him to the bone, wishing he would die in the Pu River as soon as possible.

Huang Shan was their representative.

An extremely stark contrast between characters.

Yet Guan Qingmin was saved by Huang Shan during an outing. Huang Shan thought she was just a daughter from an ordinary family. With the external environment being dangerous at the time, Huang Shan brought her back to her own home.

But Guan Qingmin fell in love with this woman at first sight and pretended to have amnesia to stay by her side.

Huang Shan pitied her and treated her extremely well.

In the midst of chaos, the two spent unforgettable days together, supporting each other as feelings quietly grew between them.

Huang Shan told Guan Qingmin about these turbulent times, about her ideals, and gave Guan Qingmin meticulous care.

In Guan Qingmin's heart, Huang Shan was the perfect lover.

But the web woven from lies was like bubbles—it all shattered the day the Guan family found her.

Huang Shan was heartbroken; Guan Qingmin washed her face with tears.

For Huang Shan's safety, Guan Qingmin left with her father and received very harsh punishment.

Huang Shan was depressed for several days before pulling herself together.

A plague spread through Guangping City. Huang Shan fell ill, and Guan Qingmin came to care for her.

The fire that had dimmed was rekindled. Guan Qingmin told her: "My father doesn't know."

Guan Qingmin was so careful and cautious around her that it broke Huang Shan's heart.

The two, just beginning to understand the taste of love, faced an impossible situation. In the end, on the night before her wedding, Guan Qingmin chose to flee from those high walls and grand courtyards, asking Huang Shan to take her away.

Huang Shan asked: "Where can we run to? Your father's spies are everywhere."

Guan Qingmin said: "Anywhere is fine."

So the two fled that deep night, only to be found at dawn the next day.

But what the Guan family's people found were only two corpses.

Two bodies lying quietly on the sandy beach by the sea, with the sea breeze continuously blowing past. They slept in silence.

This employed the technique of leaving blank space⁴, but after the blank space, one could continue searching for answers.

It turned out that after the two escaped outside the city, Huang Shan decided to send her away first while she herself would stay in Guangping City to continue the struggle.

Because there was still a major event that needed her to lead—this was her mission.

If she didn't go, many of her classmates would lose their lives.

But if she went, Guan Qingmin's parents would lose their lives.

An impossible dilemma.

The two stood by the sea. Guan Qingmin took out a gun and handed it to Huang Shan.

Huang Shan immediately understood what she meant.

And so, by the sea, the two ended their lives.

It was a BE⁵.

Turbulent times were always full of tragedies, especially loves that could never be.

The script had many blank spaces. On the first read, the two protagonists' actions seemed difficult to understand, but one would be shaken by the emotions within.

Reading the script a second time with those questions about the two protagonists, one would discover that all the tragedy had been foreshadowed.

It truly was an idealistic love.

The most ideal, most romantic ending was nothing more than ignoring the mortal world and letting everything end.

Their lives and their love ended at the same time.

In this era when sweet love stories prevailed, one had to admit that Gu Yixue really dared to write.

Even in the final scene where both died, it was Huang Shan who first killed Guan Qingmin, then shot herself in the heart.

This was an extreme test of human nature.

Unsurprisingly, this shot would definitely be a very slow shot, meant to make the audience's hearts clench.

But when Liang Shi asked Gu Yixue, Gu Yixue said: "Fast shot."

The second after Huang Shan shot Guan Qingmin, Huang Shan would without hesitation turn the gun on herself.

Only this kind of ending was worthy of the title—"Mo Journey."

After reading the script and hearing Gu Yixue's words, Liang Shi was filled with admiration. All she could say was that Gu Yixue dared to challenge human nature.

And she could find a balance between love and human nature.

Whether this script would become popular, Liang Shi didn't know.

But Liang Shi really liked this script.

She asked Gu Yixue which role she had been assigned.

Footnotes:

¹ Private school (私塾, sīshú): Traditional Chinese private schools that taught Confucian classics, typically for children from wealthy families. These were different from modern schools and focused on classical education.

² Four Books and Five Classics (四書五經): The foundational texts of Confucianism that formed the core curriculum of traditional Chinese education. They include works like the Analects of Confucius and the Book of Changes.

³ "Dream of the Red Chamber" (紅樓夢): One of China's Four Great Classical Novels, written in the 18th century. It was considered somewhat scandalous for its time due to its romantic themes and critique of feudal society, hence why reading it would be "unconventional" for a sheltered young lady.

⁴ Leaving blank space (留白): A narrative technique in Chinese storytelling and art where certain details are deliberately left unsaid or unshown, allowing the audience to fill in the gaps with their imagination. It creates a sense of artistic restraint and deeper emotional impact.

⁵ BE: Stands for "Bad Ending," internet slang commonly used in Chinese fan communities to indicate a story with a tragic or unhappy ending, as opposed to "HE" (Happy Ending).